FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

PRIORITISE REST & RECOVERY

Rest is training too

07

THE QUICK VERSION

> Growing bodies and busy minds need time to recharge. Sleep and downtime aren't time off from getting better. They're actually when the getting better happens: muscles repair, skills settle in and energy comes back.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Young athletes are juggling growth spurts, school, friendships and sport all at once. Without enough sleep and downtime, both body and mind run down, which can lead to injuries, illness, low mood and burnout. Protecting rest is one of the simplest and most powerful things you can do for your child.

HOW MUCH SLEEP DO THEY NEED?

9–12 hrs
per night, ages 6–12

8–10 hrs
per night, ages 13–18

1–2 days
off organised sport each week

Sleep guide based on recommendations from the American Academy of Sleep Medicine. Rest-day guide based on youth sport guidance from paediatric experts.

SIGNS THEY NEED MORE REST

BODY

- Heavy legs and constant tiredness
- Aches and niggles that linger

MIND

- Struggling to focus at school
- Irritable, flat or teary

GAME

- Performance dipping
- Less enthusiasm for training

TRY THIS

1. **Screens off before bed**
   Aim for 30–60 minutes screen-free before sleep. Phones charge outside the bedroom.

2. **Protect a no-sport day**
   At least one day a week with no organised training or games.

3. **Refuel and rehydrate**
   Water and a good snack or meal after training helps the body recover.

4. **Plan breaks across the year**
   Time away from their main sport between seasons keeps them fresh.

5. **Make room for other things**
   Friends, family, hobbies and plain old boredom all help recharge.

6. **Listen to pain**
   If pain lasts or keeps returning, see a physio or GP rather than pushing through.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"Your body gets stronger when you rest."	~~"Rest is for the weak."~~
"Let's have a no-football day."	~~"You can sleep when the season's over."~~
"Does anything hurt? Let's get it checked."	~~"Just push through it."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child gets close to the recommended sleep most nights
- [ ] They have at least one full rest day each week
- [ ] They get regular breaks from their main sport
- [ ] Screens are off for a while before bed

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

> **At the elite level, recovery is planned just as carefully as training. Young players deserve that same respect for their bodies.**

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM